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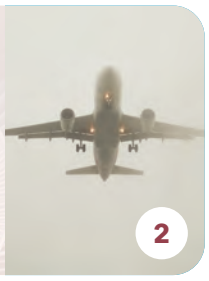
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2

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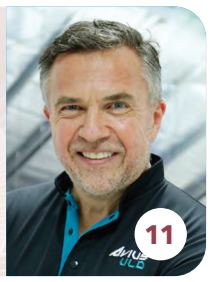
AS pharmaceutical supply chains face growing complexity, global handlers are under pressure to eliminate weak links in the cold chain. For Swissport, that ...



5

60 Seconds With ...

Charles Drummond is the CEO of AviusULD B.V., a ULD manufacturer and technology company, pioneering smart and sustainable unit load devices and ...



11



AIRSPACE INTELLIGENCE

As air cargo becomes more reliant on drones, automated middle-mile logistics, and intelligent routing, a central question emerges: how can airports coordinate rising volumes of unmanned flights without overwhelming operations? According to Yair Yosef, co-founder and CPO and COO of Airwayz, the answer lies in autonomous, intelligent airspace management. "Air cargo is evolving fast," he notes. "But without smarter coordination, the operational burden will increase sharply."

Dynamic UTM (Unmanned Traffic Management) sits at the centre of this shift. The platform is designed to provide complete visibility and control in low-altitude airspace, where manned and unmanned aircraft increasingly share limited capacity. Airports and logistics zones have become highly dynamic environments. Traditional aviation movements continue to rise, while drone operations are accelerating even faster.

Yosef identifies three immediate challenges that the upgraded Dynamic UTM is engineered to solve. "There's a lack of visibility of all unmanned activity in and around the airport perimeter," he says. "There's also difficulty managing growing drone operations without adding workload to controllers, and fragmented coordination between security, operations, and airspace teams."

Rather than adding new layers of complexity, the upgraded platform is intended to streamline operations. "Our upgraded system provides clear situational awareness, reduces the cognitive burden on staff, and enables safer, smoother coexistence between all types of aerial activity," Yosef explains. This is increasingly important at major cargo hubs, where drones already handle high-frequency movements such as urgent spares, pharmaceutical consignments, and e-commerce fulfilment loads.

Autonomous coordination of manned and unmanned aircraft

A standout capability of the Airwayz platform is its ability to manage the overlap between crewed and uncrewed flights. "We ensure safe coordination through a layered approach that combines both strategic and tactical capabilities," Yosef says.

Strategically, the system relies on Advanced Dynamic Airspace Reconfiguration. "This ensures unmanned aircraft remain clear of manned aviation corridors, restricted zones, and approach or departure paths," he explains. On the tactical level, an AI-driven prediction engine identifies potential conflicts early and suggests safe trajectories. "We apply an AI-based prediction model that detects potential conflicts early and recommends safe trajectories before risks develop."

This coordination is not only beneficial but increasingly required. With commercial airspace tightening and drone delivery networks expanding, the ability to accommodate diverse flight paths safely has become a regulatory priority.

Yosef points out that demand from cargo operations is strongly influencing the company's roadmap. "We're seeing strong demand from drone delivery, middle-mile logistics, and cargo automation programmes," he says. That demand is steering development towards "scalability and automation – handling more missions with fewer human touchpoints; and mission-level coordination – ensuring that multiple fleets can operate safely in the same zone."

Prioritisation in critical cargo scenarios

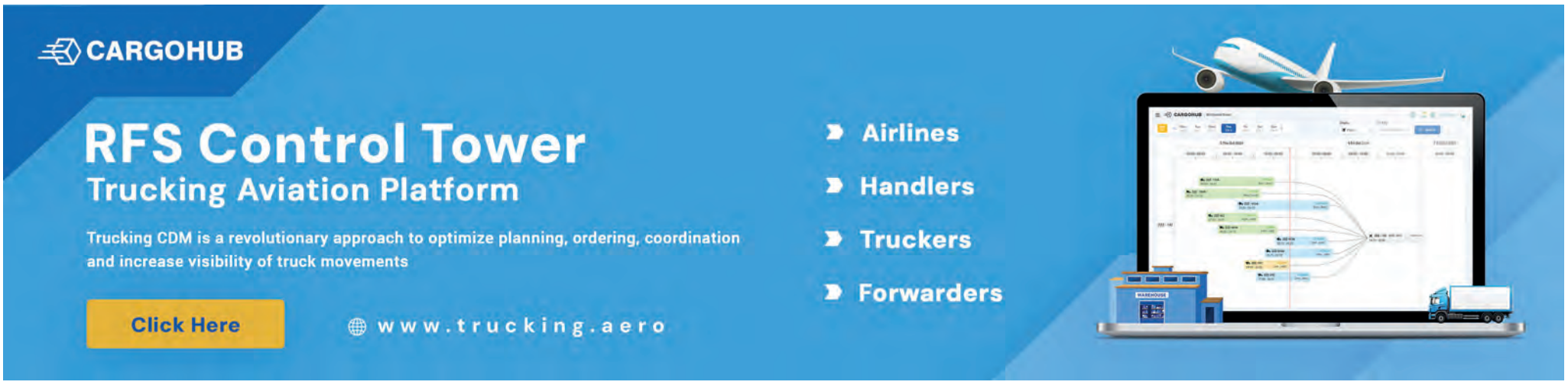
Cargo hubs also need reliable mechanisms for handling priority flights. "The system automatically identifies and prioritises critical flights," Yosef explains. "The rules and policies about prioritisation are pre-configurated by the Airspace Authority." Once a priority mission is detected, "it gets immediate access, protected air corridors, and nearby missions are adjusted in real time to keep the airspace safe."

A shared operational picture

One long-standing challenge for airports is stakeholder fragmentation. Yosef argues that the new Dynamic UTM directly addresses this. "One of the core strengths of the new version is its ability to serve as a single operational layer for all stakeholders," he says. "Airspace managers, airport security, drone operators, regulators, and even terminal teams can all work from the same picture and the same ruleset."

Airports typically achieve independence within weeks. Success, Yosef says, is defined by "full visibility of all drone activity; reduced workload for airport staff; and safer, smoother operations with fewer manual interventions."

Dynamic UTM also generates periodic insights into airspace usage. "This helps airports plan staffing and resources, improve safety planning, understand future demand, and identify opportunities for monetising drone operations," he notes.





UNITED CARGO AND CARGO.ONE ADD TO WAVE OF DIGITAL ADOPTION

BY **Edward HARDY**

IN recent years, freight forwarders of all sizes have realised the benefits of digital procurement and sales. Expanding networks and investment in more agile services give forwarders the edge to quote faster, win more business, and scale globally. In a co-ordinated push, carriers, forwarders, and digital booking platforms are collaborating to unlock further growth with digital tools.

In response to demand, cargo.one has now become the first marketplace to offer United Cargo's Passive TC capacity. United Cargo has also just rolled out QuickPak services on cargo.one. The enhancements aim to capitalise on the evolving needs of customers and expand service capabilities.

Reflecting strong transpacific demand in particular, United Cargo is set to launch additional markets on the platform in the coming weeks. These include Korea, Japan, Australia, and New Zealand — further solidifying the global nature of the digital proposition and the partners' commitment to meeting customer demand.

"Since the launch of our partnership, we have seen robust adoption rates, particularly in Europe and the USA. Customers in these regions have embraced the platform, integrating it seamlessly into their digital workflows to enhance booking operations," Christine Rogljacin, Senior Manager Cargo Marketing and eCommerce, United Cargo, said.

"Our collaboration has significantly improved booking efficiency for customers. By providing streamlined digital access to United Cargo's capacity, cargo.one reduces the time and effort required for bookings, enabling faster and more reliable operations," she continued.

"United Cargo and cargo.one have established a productive and collaborative rhythm, focusing on evolving the customer experience. Our work with cargo.one is driven by a shared commitment to responding to market needs and delivering innovative solutions that enhance the overall user journey."



IMPACT OF FOG ON AVIATION

BY **Michael SALES**

Despite new technologies, fog still constitutes a major danger for aviation. Mist is defined as occurring when the visibility is greater than one km, while fog occurs when the visibility is less than one km. Depending on the season, airport fog results in thousands of flight delays and cancellations worldwide.

There are several types of fog. Radiation fog occurs when the land surface loses its heat to the atmosphere. Valley fog occurs when cold air settles in the troughs of a valley and, as it condenses, fog forms. Advection fog occurs when warm, moist air moves over the top of a colder surface. If this air mass cools to the dew point, fog will form.

Precision Air Flight 494 crash in Tanzania (November 2022): An ATR 42 aircraft crashed into Lake Victoria while attempting to land in adverse weather and low visibility conditions. The pilots did not maintain adequate visual reference and failed to respond to automated alerts to go around, resulting in 19 fatalities.

Air traffic control (ATC) and pilots manoeuvre aircraft movements through maps and visual cues. However, when fog hits the airport and visibility drops under 600 metres, airports switch to Low Visibility Procedures (LVPs). These LVPs alter operations significantly to ensure more space and time on the airfield.

The most complicated part of flying during fog is taxiing to the runway. The lack of visuals means pilots and ATC are forced to rely on maps and limited visual-led communications. Aircraft may go to holding point CAT 2 or 3 instead of a usual CAT 1, adding up to hundreds of metres more to the holding point.

Aircraft anti-fog technology involves both external coatings and internal heating systems. Anti-fog coatings are hydrophilic treatments that prevent water from forming droplets on surfaces like windows and instrument panels, while anti-fog heaters are electrical elements that warm the glass to prevent condensation.



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Forwarders view the combined offer of global network capacity and marketplace integration as a commercial advantage. Digital tools are becoming embedded in rate management and quoting functions, enabling teams to respond to customer requests at pace. cargo.one's user base now includes many of the world's largest forwarders, which use marketplace APIs to power internal platforms and transport management systems.

"Without a doubt, United Cargo is one of the most important and in-demand carriers on cargo.one. Our partnership is highly successful because forwarders really value such easy-to-use and flexible digital access to United Cargo capacity, which enables them to quote fast and win more shipments," Simson Demmer, Chief Customer Officer at cargo.one, said.

"By combining cargo.one's digital efficiency with United Cargo's comprehensive capacity, freight forwarders can secure more business, deepen partnerships, and provide clients with flexible, high-quality solutions," he continued. "cargo.one is also at the forefront of delivering forwarding teams increasing value from AI – so bringing United Cargo rates within effortless AI-powered quoting workflows provides them a convenient and scalable way to quote faster and win more shipments."

The roadmap

Both partners are planning further enhancements to their digital proposition, including deeper integration, additional product categories, and tools that support more automated booking journeys. United Cargo is also investing in internal training so sales teams can support customers using marketplace channels. Feedback loops between both organisations will drive service improvements and ensure new features align with forwarder expectations.

"We aim to continually enhance our offerings on cargo.one. Through ongoing refinements to the integration, United Cargo and cargo.one teams work to ensure that freight forwarders have access to seamless and dependable booking experiences," Rogljacin said. "As part of its omni-channel digital strategy, United Cargo is investing in internal training for sales teams and support staff. This initiative equips them with the knowledge and tools to effectively leverage cargo.one, ensuring they can better serve customers and maximise the platform's potential."

"United Cargo is exploring deeper integration of specialty products and promotional rates tailored specifically for marketplace users. The joint roadmap between United Cargo and cargo.one focuses on innovation in areas like dynamic pricing, improved shipment tracking, and enhanced service transparency. These advancements aim to deliver a more responsive and efficient experience for customers."

Cargo.one expects rapid scaling of digital procurement across the industry. As more carriers expand digital distribution and forwarders intensify automation efforts, the marketplace model is becoming central to rate visibility, pricing responsiveness, and sourcing workflows. The partnership structure also shows how carriers can use external platforms to enhance digital sales without replacing internal tools.

"cargo.one offers airline partners like United Cargo the best experience in the market for optimising their digital sales growth. Our partnerships, product, and operations teams support United Cargo to ensure that it remains fully responsive to market demands and has optimal offerings for every relevant market," Demmer said. "Together with the United Cargo team, we are able to continually bring new markets and capacity types to forwarders working digitally. Cargo.one is innovating rapidly around AI quoting, and as we deliver even more speed and convenience to users, United Cargo can benefit from rapid quotes turning into rapid bookings.

"For the industry at large, our partnership with United Cargo reflects how rapidly we can successfully scale efficient, digital airfreight procurement and so enhance service levels for many thousands of shippers."









BECAUSE EXCELLENCE STARTS BEHIND THE SCENES

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QUIET REVOLUTION IN PHARMA HANDLING

BY **Anastasiya SIMSEK**

AS pharmaceutical supply chains face growing complexity, global handlers are under pressure to eliminate weak links in the cold chain. For Swissport, that means re-engineering its infrastructure around predictability, precision, and real-time visibility.

Dirk Goovaerts, CEO for the CEMEAI region at Swissport, says the company is building "cool facilities with intelligence baked in", aiming to create a replicable model that works as consistently in Johannesburg as it does in Basel.

"We have decided to set the standards with airside proximity, also in a modular layout, and we provide direct access from the ramp into the cool facility. So, we shorten the distance, and we also reduce the dwell time," Goovaerts told Air Cargo Week.

That attention to spatial design and time control is part of a broader rethink of how Swissport handles temperature-sensitive cargo — from door-to-door flow to predictive risk management.

Infrastructure built for pharma, not adapted to it

During the pandemic, the handling of vaccines forced many operators to retrofit existing facilities or rely on fragmented workarounds. Swissport took a different route: it used the urgency to establish repeatable, specialised infrastructure — most notably in its pharma corridors, which have now become a global model.

"We have these kinds of facilities in about 25 airports worldwide, fully certified CEIV , but also GDP," Goovaerts said.

At major hubs like Basel and Frankfurt, Swissport's "Edge" facilities incorporate multiple temperature-controlled zones (including -20°C for ultra-cold cargo), shorter transfer paths, and prioritised acceptance lanes for pharma. Automated material handling systems move ULDs without manual intervention, minimising human error and temperature excursions.

"We apply the same principles as we have in our other cool facilities in the network... and we have embedded [them] into an automated material handling system so that the ULDs or the pallets can move very fast without manual intervention."

This reduces not only dwell time but also labour intensity — a point of growing importance as workforce constraints remain a persistent issue across ground handling.

Swissport's scalable model

A key differentiator in Swissport's strategy is standardisation. From facility layout to SOPs and IT systems, the company is aiming for network-wide consistency without compromising local agility.

"Our systems are designed for resilience, redundant power, and automated alerts to keep our cargo safe," Goovaerts said. "In any temperature-controlled environment... any deviation triggers an immediate intervention."

This system not only alerts duty managers in real-time — via email or SMS — but also locks all alerts for post-event analysis, ensuring exceptions are tracked and lessons are captured.

"The fact that it is an automatic alert means that it's automatically addressed, but it's not forgotten. We work with management by exception. We would like our leadership to analyse the exceptions, to learn from that, and then share best practices."

Logistics meets design thinking

Swissport's redesign of pharma facilities is not just about compliance ; it's about embedding resilience into the architecture of the cold chain. In practice, that means shorter distances, automated flows, fewer interventions, and more embedded intelligence.

This approach is now being extended to other verticals. "We have introduced, let's say, a flower corridor... a replication of the pharma corridor," Goovaerts said. "It's fully temperature-controlled, and can be used for flower principles, but also for pharma."

The modularity of the "Edge" model allows Swissport to adapt its facilities to different commodities and climatic conditions, without starting from scratch. The focus is less on infrastructure as a static asset , and more as a dynamic enabler.

Temperature control is energy-intensive, and Swissport is well aware of the sustainability trade-offs. The company has committed to reaching 55 percent electric GSE by 2032 and net zero by 2050. But more immediately, it is retrofitting and designing facilities to reduce operational emissions now.

"We are introducing, and we have already, solar-powered warehouses. And I think with the solar power, that's how we then provide the electricity for the freezers and so on," Goovaerts said.

Sustainability is built into the facility design — from semi-automated roller decks that remove the need for forklifts, to energy-efficient cooling technologies sourced from suppliers focused on reducing consumption. These choices also improve workplace safety by reducing manual handling and vehicle traffic inside warehouses.

"We are integrating sustainability in our cool chain through efficient systems and mostly electrified equipment, powered by solar."



HOW TRANSPORT LEADERS ARE STEERING THROUGH THE US TARIFF MAZE



BY **Oscar SARDINAS**

If one word defined the mood across three policy-heavy sessions at air cargo Americas, it would have to be uncertainty. Executives described 2025 as the most erratic regulatory year in recent memory, one where tariff proposals, enforcement priorities, and political messaging shifted fast enough to distort planning cycles and force shippers into reaction mode.

What came about in Miami was the sense that tariff instability is no longer a macro backdrop. It's now a direct operational variable, influencing booking rhythms, modal decisions, and shipper behaviour on both sides of the US border.

Tariff volatility becomes a supply-chain disruptor

Panelists were clear that 2025's challenge was not the level of tariffs but the erratic process behind them. Rules changed without warning, implementation dates slipped, and rumours moved markets.

Luis Hernandez, Executive Vice President of Intermodal Grupo Mexico Transportes, summed the problem up best: "Tariffs are announced today, may apply tomorrow, or may not."

This policy whiplash drove importers to accelerate shipments to beat potential increases, only to pause when Washington signalled delays. These irregularities created pressure at US gateways, with airfreight repeatedly acting as the corrective mode when time was of the essence.

Even proposals that never advanced, such as the White House's threatened 50 percent tariff on Chinese imports, were destabilising enough to shift booking patterns.

Nearshoring vs near sourcing: Pinpointing the real trend

Panelists also warned against conflating nearshoring headlines with the underlying data. While Mexico continues to gain strength as a supplier to the US, the expected wave of foreign factory relocations has not materialised.

Diego Rodriguez of Americas Market Intelligence clarified the reality: "90 percent of Mexico's foreign direct investment is just reinvestment from companies already in Mexico."

Mexico's export growth is therefore driven by near sourcing, Mexican producers supplying more to US buyers, not by large-scale relocation from Asia. That means the global tariff environment, particularly US–China measures, continues to influence demand patterns even as North American integration deepens.

USMCA renewal adds another layer of risk

The upcoming 2026 USMCA review dominated much of the policy discussion. Most speakers believed renewal is the most likely outcome, but a politically charged negotiation is to be expected.

"Mexico will have to sit at the table and offer concessions... the USMCA will be renewed next year," Rodriguez also predicted, pointing to energy and China-alignment issues as flashpoints.

The uncertainty surrounding the review is already prompting shippers to diversify routes and seek customs advisory support, behaviour airlines say has become more prevalent.

Border unpredictability boosts airfreight

For many operators, the most disruptive factor of 2025 was inconsistent enforcement at US–Mexico border crossings, not tariff levels themselves. Representatives from the US–Mexico Chamber of Commerce said unclear guidance routinely left goods stuck in procedural limbo.

These hold-ups repeatedly redirected time-sensitive loads into air networks. Several carriers said northbound demand spikes reflected shippers trying to bypass unpredictable land queues as much as avoiding tariff timing.

Strategic gains

Another clear theme was the rising importance of freight forwarders and customs brokers. With tariff rules shifting quickly and enforcement tightening, shippers increasingly relied on intermediaries to interpret policies, verify documentation, and build contingency plans.

Rodriguez described a sharp change in customer behaviour: "We're seeing shippers coming to us asking: how can we beat this? What alternatives do we have?"

This dynamic has strengthened forwarders' position along the US–Mexico corridor and encouraged larger BCOs to centralise compliance oversight.

Friction in transatlantic trade

Policy volatility was not limited to North America this year. Speakers warned that competing emissions rules, subsidy frameworks, and digital-trade agendas could add more uncertainty next year. Although not as volatile as the US–Mexico environment, transatlantic flows are being shaped by regulatory divergence that may affect capacity planning and compliance costs.

Several panelists argued that policy risk has become a permanent operating condition, not a cyclical disruption.

Policy unpredictability: The new normal

The consensus from air cargo Americas was clear: more volatility is on the horizon. With more US–China tariff escalations still at play, USMCA negotiations approaching, and an election year looming, shippers are expanding their supplier bases, diversifying markets, and using airfreight to make their networks more resilient.

For airfreight operators, the lesson from 2025 is clear: agility is now the industry's defining competitive advantage. In a year when policy signals moved markets faster than fuel prices, being able to react, rather than merely plan, has become a key differentiator.

"Tariffs are announced today, may apply tomorrow, or may not."



THE DIGITAL REVOLUTION IN COLD CHAIN LOGISTICS

The growing adoption of bespoke digital tools is revolutionising how pharmaceutical shipments are planned, executed and monitored. Smart logistics platforms now enable data-driven decisions across the entire supply chain, using historical data to optimise routes, minimise delays and boost reliability.

Predictive algorithms can assess lane risk and forecast weather disruptions, allowing teams to proactively reroute shipments before issues arise. Real-time visibility empowers swift action, helping resolve problems before they affect product quality or delivery timelines.

This level of operational intelligence is especially critical in cold chain logistics, where even slight temperature deviations can compromise the efficacy of the products being distributed. By reducing risk and enhancing efficiency, these digital tools help ensure life-saving medicines reach patients safely and on time.

CCT Smart Solutions

The CCT Smart Solutions platform is an example of how digital tools can simplify logistics planning from start to finish, delivering value across four critical phases, Planning, Execution, Monitoring and Optimization

Our smart selection engine, for example, suggests the right packaging solution for each shipment dependent on a comprehensive assessment of relevant parameters.

Additionally, Smart Solutions integrates carrier logistics data, cellular data loggers (IoT), real time thermal modelling and geofencing technology to provide a precise view of each shipment, allowing for rapid problem identification and resolution.

Intelligent data management, also a feature of our Smart Solutions platform, is another way digital technology can have a huge impact on cold chain operations. By collating data from every shipment, smart technology can analyse route performance, track regular deviations, monitor thermal behaviour and more. With this information, companies can use tools like Smart Solutions to reduce waste, lower costs, improve reliability and - most importantly - protect product integrity from manufacturer to patient.

From a sustainability perspective, CCT Smart Solutions' Reusable Program Dashboard application provides users with the in-depth information required to hit ESG proof points. Customers using reusable shippers, can review, analyze, and optimize their reusable shipping initiatives for maximum efficiency. It captures on time return rates, renew cycle, the number of on time returns, the number of late and lost shippers and landfill savings calculations, allowing for financial and environmental efficiencies.

The Human Touch

Whilst digital solutions can provide major advantages to those operating in cold chain logistics, it is still vital that these are supplemented with human expertise and robust physical infrastructure. Cold Chain Technologies, for example, offers tailored support structures which can help manage challenges such as rerouting critical shipments or troubleshooting temperature excursions. These advisory services are bolstered by a network of 50 regional hubs, providing regional support and stock availability across 20 countries.

A combination of digital tools which deliver real-time visibility, data management and operational efficiencies and specialist human support is critical for efficient management of temperature sensitive shipping. The increasing capability of these digital tools is changing cold chain logistics, and choosing providers which offer these can not only ensure the integrity of products but a host of benefits from simplifying compliance to maximising resource efficiency and risk mitigation.



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DISRUPTION TO REINVENTION: WHAT 2025 TAUGHT AIR CARGO, AND WHAT'S IN LINE FOR 2026

BY **Oscar SARDINAS**

Air cargo Americas carried a sentiment that defined the event: 2025 wasn't just another volatile year for the airfreight industry, it was a transformational one. Capacity distortions, infrastructure strain, freight theft concerns, and the relentless rise of e-commerce forced the sector to rethink long-held assumptions about how it operates. Yet the tone in Miami was crystal clear: air cargo is entering 2026 more adaptive, more digitised, and more regionally interconnected than at any point since the pandemic.

Uneven recovery and structural distortions

While passenger travel strengthened, cargo operators were reminded that belly freight has not fully recovered, and likely won't for some time. One panelist observed that while not always discussed, the continued exclusion of many carriers from Russian airspace remains a "silent capacity drag on trans-Pacific long-haul operations."

The result? A year marked by unpredictable capacity swings, where carriers serving Asia–Americas and Asia–LATAM flows absorbed demand spikes at short notice.

A new e-commerce baseline

If 2024 reintroduced volume after a sluggish period, 2025 redefined expectations. Amazon Air's Business Development Director Kes Nielsen stated that customers have now normalised accelerated convenience.

The company's 98.9 percent on-time performance became a benchmark referenced throughout the conference. Nielsen framed the stakes succinctly:

"Customer expectations aren't static, they compound."

For airfreight, that means rising demand for late cut-offs, rapid uplift, online booking, and tighter first-mile/last-mile integration.

Infrastructure strain: A frontline issue

2025 did expose a few infrastructure cracks, not in headline disasters but in daily operational friction. Alliance Ground International CEO Jared Azcuy drew attention to what some view as a strain: workforce onboarding.

"It can take six to eight weeks to badge a new employee at some airports," Azcuy says.

For handlers already stretched thin, that delay directly reduces ramp efficiency. AGI reported meaningful progress in digitising processes, but the industry remains uneven. Some airports are testing 15–30 minute truck-turn targets, while others maintain paper-based workflows and personalised service. While Latin America has taken a few strides, inland transport costs and outdated customs procedures still add friction.

Rewired American supply chains

2025 saw a decisive shift in how the Americas think about supply chains. Brazil, Chile, and Colombia continued their evolution from "export-centric" economies to major e-commerce consumer markets, changing flow patterns and encouraging new widebody freighter services.

Mexico has remained the centre of gravity, but experts emphasised that 2025 was the year of "near-sourcing" rather than large-scale nearshoring. Domestic producers increased US shipments, yet FDI inflows were dominated by reinvestment rather than new factory projects.

Speakers highlighted new momentum in the Dominican Republic, Costa Rica, and Guatemala, which are becoming part of the extended North American production base. More direct Asia–LATAM freighter links, including 777 and 747 routes into São Paulo, Santiago, and Bogotá, have helped diversify sourcing options and reduce reliance on US transhipment.

Safety, security and theft concerns

Freight theft resurfaced as a major concern in 2025, particularly in Mexico, Brazil, and parts of the US. In response, carriers and handlers are expanding camera-based AI safety monitoring, hardening high-value storage facilities, and relying more heavily on bonded trucking networks.

The concern isn't just limited to high-value electronics or pharmaceuticals. Speakers noted that even general cargo can be a target, with organised groups using increasingly sophisticated tactics. In May, for example, bandits posing as police officers stopped a truck carrying sound equipment for cumbia band Los Ángeles Azules on the Mexico–Puebla highway, drew weapons, and drove off with the cargo—a high-profile example of the fake checkpoint schemes becoming more common on major routes. Such incidents exploit gaps in visibility during air-to-ground handoffs and highway transit.

Security was repeatedly identified as a top-five industry concern for 2026, with operators calling for greater collaboration between carriers, handlers, and law enforcement.

Partnerships: The new infrastructure

Partnerships are the new infrastructure, and the next decade will reward companies that align early with strategic partners. This was clear in air carriers deepening ties with handlers, tech firms, and forwarders, and in growing recognition that no actor can meet demand, digitise, comply with shifting rules, and maintain service reliability alone.

2026: A year that will reward preparedness

Looking ahead, executives agreed that 2026 will naturally bring election-year policy risk, USMCA review uncertainty, shifting Asia–LATAM demand, continued freighter reliance, and deeper scrutiny of customs and compliance across the region.

That said, the tone was optimistic. The industry enters 2026 more agile, more collaborative, and more technologically capable than at any time prior to the pandemic.

If 2025 was the year the industry learned to move through disruption, 2026 may be the year it turns volatility into opportunity.

"Customer expectations aren't static, they compound."



MEETING RISING DEMAND FOR PRECISION THERAPIES

BY **Edward HARDY**

"The shift from a one-size-fits-all treatment model to a more personalised approach aims to enhance efficiency."



Investment in temperature-controlled airfreight and handling facilities across the Americas is increasing as pharmaceutical producers expand in Puerto Rico, the United States, and emerging Latin American markets. Carriers and handlers are adding certified storage capacity, trained staff, and real-time monitoring systems to support biologics, vaccines, and advanced therapies that require strict temperature controls.

Growth in cell and gene therapies, as well as personalised medicines, is driving smaller and more frequent shipments that require tighter monitoring and shorter handling timelines. Providers are focusing on end-to-end visibility and contingency planning as regulators and shippers place greater emphasis on product integrity.

Eric Mathieu, Managing Director of Customer Experience at American Airlines Cargo, said Puerto Rico is becoming a central production location. "Puerto Rico is a leading force in global pharmaceutical manufacturing and is home to production operations for almost all the world's major companies in the sector," he said. "Investment in CEIV certification, cold-chain infrastructure, and highly trained staff gives shippers the confidence that we can deliver the reliable service they require."

Infrastructure expansion and regulatory alignment

Pharmaceutical manufacturers and supply chain partners are increasing validated storage capacity and upgrading handling protocols to reduce exposure during loading, unloading, and airport transfer. The focus is on minimising time on the tarmac, ensuring controlled storage temperatures, and improving coordination between airlines, forwarders, and ground handlers.

In Latin America, governments and industry are continuing to review cold-chain capabilities to support biologics exports and imports. "In Latin America, there are continuous conversations between governments and international organisations to evaluate and invest in a cold-chain infrastructure that minimises the risk of temperature deviations during transit," said Mathieu.

Differences between good distribution practice regulations in the United States, Canada, and Latin American markets continue to require operational flexibility. "Regulatory frameworks share common principles but differ in scope, enforcement, and harmonisation levels," Mathieu said.

Digital monitoring, contingency planning and sustainability pressures

Carriers are introducing real-time temperature monitoring, automated alerts, and central control towers to provide intervention during irregular operations. These measures support rerouting, re-icing, and container replacement where necessary to avoid temperature excursions.

American Airlines Cargo has developed a strategy to improve visibility and temperature assurance throughout the shipment process. "Strong, real-time coordination between our teams and our customers is key," said Mathieu. "Our 24/7 control tower provides monitoring and support for irregular operations and any other potential delays to the shipment journey."

"This ensures transparency and swift action when needed, and our robust contingency measures are in place to safeguard the cargo and maintain trust," he said.

Sustainability considerations are influencing packaging and transport choices, although pharmaceutical integrity remains the priority. Active monitoring enables the use of more efficient packaging systems and optimisation of container use.

Investment is also driven by the shift towards smaller batch therapies. Advanced biologics and cell and gene therapies frequently require temperatures between 2–8°C or as low as -70°C, and are often moved in clinical-trial-sized quantities. Providers are investing in capacity to support these shipments with shorter lead times and increased responsiveness.

Looking to 2030

The growth of personalised medicine is expected to reshape capacity planning and logistics models. Smaller doses, rapid deployment, and stringent temperature requirements will increase the importance of certified facilities and real-time network coordination across the Americas.

Stakeholders expect growth in both multinational and emerging biotech activity in Latin America, alongside continued investment in certified airport infrastructure in Puerto Rico and major US gateways. The key pressure point remains ensuring end-to-end temperature control while maintaining operational resilience across varied regulatory environments.

Mathieu said precision medicine will demand specialised supply chains. "The shift from a one-size-fits-all treatment model to a more personalised approach aims to enhance efficiency," he said. "Predictive analytics and the use of AI for enhanced route optimisation and greater end-to-end visibility are expected to evolve further, creating new opportunities for innovation and investment."



BEYOND THE THERMAL PACKAGING

BY **Edward HARDY**

When it comes to moving time- and temperature-sensitive pharmaceuticals, the integrity of cold chain shipments depends on much more than the packaging itself.

"One can choose a packaging solution, but if you give it to someone who doesn't have the right trained staff to handle it, the right facility, the right processes in place, and the right airline, you are naturally asking for trouble at the end of the day," Bourji Mourad, Director of Global Leasing and Market Development at Sonoco ThermoSafe, explained.

Thermal packaging is critical, but it cannot always compensate for weaknesses elsewhere in the supply chain. "People often focus on the temperature-control container (TCC), for example, thinking it's going to protect the product under all circumstances. That's a misconception," Mourad says. "A TCC alone cannot account for trade lane variability, storage conditions at intermediate hubs, or delays due to customs clearance. It's the combination of correct packaging, processes, facilities, visibility, and people that ensures life-saving products arrive safely."

Critical control points

Every shipment faces unique challenges depending on its trade lane, temperature-sensitive product, packaging, and airline used. "Not every trade lane is the same. Shipping from the northern hemisphere to the southern hemisphere, the temperature ranges are different. You have areas where destinations could take much longer to clear cargo. If we're shipping to some of the airports in South America, for example, it could take a lot longer than airports in other countries to release pharmaceutical products," he says.

Delays can mean that even the best packaging is left vulnerable during storage or transport, exposing sensitive medicines to potential temperature excursions.

There are multiple touch points where temperature deviations can occur. "You talk in an excess of ten critical control points from door to door. Then there's the last mile from the distribution centre or consignee to the clinic or patient. There are so many other critical control points as well," Mourad adds. Every stage requires trained personnel, regularly calibrated equipment, and proper procedures. "Even if your packaging is perfect, without the correct handling and visibility at these points, the time- and temperature-sensitive product is at risk," he explains.

Trade lane complexity also affects contingency planning. "Some hubs are extremely efficient, others are less so. Even minor delays can compound if the staff are untrained or procedures are inconsistent. This is why risk analysis must precede the selection of packaging solutions. It's not just about what packaging keeps the product at a certain temperature — it's about the entire journey," Mourad says.

Contingency management

One lesson highlighted during the pandemic was the importance of redundancy in the supply chain. "Once a pharma company has qualified a packaging solution, it's a long-winded process to qualify another. If they didn't have a backup plan, what happens when there aren't enough TCCs or similar packaging available at a particular location?" Mourad says.

"Even if you have the perfect packaging at origin, if the destination or transit doesn't have the right facilities, everything can go wrong. That's why you must look into trade lane risk analysis before committing to a packaging solution or provider," he explains. Backup plans, multiple providers, and alternative logistics routes are now as critical as the container itself.

Mourad adds that collaboration across the supply chain has also become essential. "During COVID, forwarders shared aircraft capacity, and airlines removed seats to carry cargo on upper decks. Cooperation was key. Without that level of planning and flexibility, many shipments would have failed," he notes.

Sustainability and innovation

Packaging providers are under increasing pressure to balance thermal performance with sustainability. Mourad explains, "We are very much into the innovation side of things. We're working on materials that are lighter, more sustainable, with longer thermal performance. In addition to bulk reusable Temperature Control Containers, we've introduced reusable parcel-size thermal packaging under a rental model alongside our single-use packaging solutions."

While sustainability is a growing priority, pharmaceutical companies often must weigh it against speed and availability. "Sometimes the most sustainable option isn't available everywhere. In those cases, reliability and speed take precedence," he says. Still, innovation is a key differentiator in the market, improving both environmental outcomes and the ability to maintain consistent temperatures.

For Mourad, the overarching message is clear: thermal packaging and Temperature Control Containers are necessary, but they are not sufficient on their own. Successful cold chain logistics require trained staff, careful planning, backup strategies, and ongoing innovation. "Packaging is a critical piece, but it's just one element. Without trained personnel, standard operating procedures, partnering with approved providers, contingency planning, and trade lane awareness, even the most advanced packaging cannot guarantee the integrity of life-saving products in transit," he concludes.

"You must look into trade lane risk analysis before committing to a packaging solution or provider."





AI IN THE INBOX

BY **Anastasiya SIMSEK**

AS the air cargo industry wrestles with digitisation at scale, artificial intelligence is shifting from hype to implementation. And according to Matt Petot, founder and CEO of CargoAi, that shift is happening directly inside the inbox.

While many forwarders and airlines are still navigating basic e-booking adoption, CargoAi's latest push embeds AI tools into quoting, pricing, and customer interaction — automating everything from rate prediction to natural language email replies. If it works as claimed, it could significantly raise productivity without overhauling legacy systems.

Conversational AI

CargoAi's approach puts AI front and centre in its booking platform, CargoMART, but avoids separating it into standalone apps. Instead, AI operates under the hood — predicting rates, identifying the best routing options, and now responding to emails.

"Our new CargoCopilot AI Agent is a full conversational interface," Petot says. "Forwarders can simply type 'Book 300 kg from SIN to LHR next Tuesday' or 'Show me rates to JFK', and get instant results." Airlines and GSAs, he adds, are using the same tool to triage thousands of customer emails daily — from availability checks to delivery instructions.

While digital quoting tools are not new, Petot argues that AI turns static interfaces into dynamic decision-makers. "It's not just about speed. It's about replacing repetition with reasoning."

One of the key differentiators Petot highlights is that CargoAi trains its models in-house using its own proprietary dataset — not third-party or public LLMs.

"Our LLMs are trained by us, on our own servers, with our own dataset," he explains. "That ensures customer data is never shared, never exposed, and never used to train public models."

The dataset in question spans millions of searches, quotes, and bookings from more than 150 countries. Combined with anonymised industry inputs and upcoming integrations with IATA ONE Record, the result is a rare blend: transaction-level data at global scale.

This data allows the platform to make predictions that, in Petot's words, "no single airline's RMS can make." For instance, it can forecast with up to 90 percent accuracy which offer a forwarder is likely to accept — giving carriers a chance to optimise offers in real time.

CargoAi claims its tools deliver measurable returns, especially for forwarders caught between growing volumes and limited resources.

"For mid-sized forwarders, we see 30–50 percent faster quote response times and a 10–15 percent uplift in conversion rates," Petot says. "One Southeast Asian forwarder processed four times more quotes per rep within 90 days — without adding headcount."

On the airline side, the automation scale is more aggressive. "One GSA now processes over 10,000 quotes per month automatically. That's not proof of concept. That's production."

Beyond volume, Petot is keen to stress that the models prioritise profitability, not just filling space. "Our models are built to protect yield. In volatile markets, the system adapts its priorities in real time — volume never comes at the expense of margin."

That might be the most important distinction. AI in air cargo often leans toward speed and automation, but ignoring revenue management nuances would risk cutting into the very profits it promises to boost.

What may appear at first as an email plugin is, in fact, where Petot sees the real strategic shift — using email content, CRM history, and booking data to personalise offers and automate replies without compromising on context.

"The Agent understands cargo type, service level, even past negotiation patterns," he says. "When confidence is high, it responds instantly. When it's low, it flags for human review."

The decision to build in confidence scoring — and keep a "human-in-the-loop" for sensitive or complex requests — reflects a practical understanding of how AI tools should operate in regulated, high-value logistics.

Surprisingly, this is also attracting smaller forwarders who aren't running full TMS platforms. "Over 40 percent of our plugin users don't use a TMS," Petot notes. "They connect via email or CargoMART directly — no system overhaul needed."

That's no small detail. With much of the industry still running on email, spreadsheets, and semi-structured workflows, AI adoption needs to meet users where they are — not demand a digital leap they're not ready for.

Despite the progress, Petot admits the industry remains divided. A few airlines are leaning into full integration — seeing clear gains in quoting speed, conversion, and load factor management. But many remain stuck in pilot mode.

"Adoption speed matters more than ever," he warns. "AI compounds its advantages: faster learning, better data, more market share. The performance gap between early adopters and latecomers will be huge."



SBD
International Airport
Southern California's Cargo Connection



SAN BERNARDINO INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT SOARS

As the airfreight market in North America evolves, the role of San Bernardino International Airport (SBD) in this industry segment continues to climb. Once an Air Force base, the airport is now a thriving player in air cargo.

In 2016 UPS initiated seasonal service as the sole cargo carrier at SBD. Since that time, the airport has experienced uninterrupted annual growth, placing it in the nation's top 25 busiest air cargo airports. SBD is well situated in the Inland Empire region of Southern California with easy access to the entire LA basin. "Trade is crucial to California, a state that serves as a significant hub for various transit methods, including major shipping ports and logistical points. At SBD, we continue to accommodate air cargo growth," Mark Gibbs, Director of Aviation for San Bernardino, stated. "California's logistics landscape is significant; while New York is the largest market in the US, Los Angeles is the second largest, and SBD is ideally situated to serve all Southern California. Our airport is an excellent launching point to Asia, providing great market access while maintaining low operational costs. These key advantages have attracted the nation's largest integrated cargo carriers to include San Bernardino in their growth plans."

Trade lanes and inter-modality

The connectivity at San Bernardino International Airport has steadily improved over time. Initially, focused on connecting to larger hub cities, it has now developed into its own major cargo hub. Today, the airport serves as Amazon's second-largest hub in the United States, following their primary hub in Cincinnati (CVG).

As SBD has expanded in size, it has allowed for more growth and diversification. For example, FedEx connects to its main hub in Memphis, while UPS operates to various markets. "When we first began our partnership with UPS, followed by FedEx the next year, we quickly realized the potential challenge of an increasing number of trucks at the airport. To address,





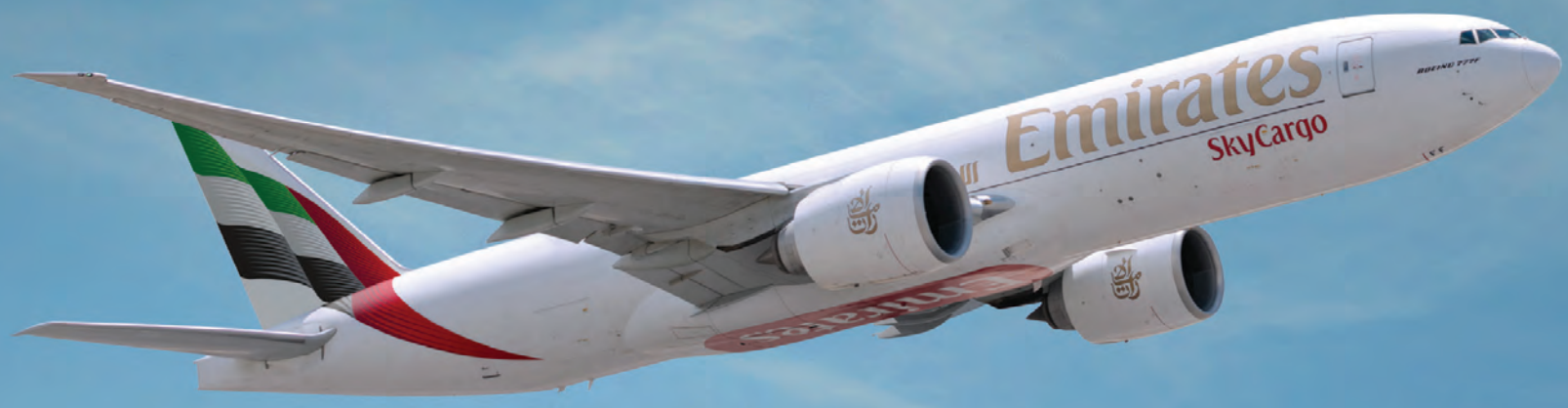
we took proactive measures that enhanced efficiency and streamlined operations for our carriers," Gibbs explained. "We constructed a dedicated cargo-only truck entrance to the airport, which includes a high-speed off-ramp designed to accommodate multiple lanes. This setup minimizes the interference between trucks and other vehicles, ensuring smoother traffic flow. Additionally, we have an actively managed security station specifically for trucks, providing a quick and secure entry and exit process. These improvements have significantly enhanced efficiency for both the trucks and all other airport users, and we have seen considerable success as a result."

Environmental mindset

The 100-acre Amazon development at SBD was specifically designed with net-zero emissions in mind, making it the first of its kind in the world. Every piece of equipment on-site is electric, whether it's a cargo loader, tug, forklift, or pushback tug. The site has 73 charging stations built for industrial-grade equipment, ensuring that the entire operation runs on electricity. Additionally, a 650,000-square-foot cargo building is topped with solar panels, generating enough energy to power about 1,000 homes. This commitment to clean energy is evident throughout the Amazon hub. The company has done an outstanding job of setting the standard and being responsible stewards in their pursuit of sustainability. "We can all strive to do our part and be responsible stewards of the environment, and we are committed to doing just that," Gibbs highlighted. "Right now, we're seeing early efforts toward a cleaner environment with various technologies emerging. "It's really about technology catching up with market demand. It's hard to predict with certainty what the dominant energy source of the future will be, as there are many competing options."

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CHARLES DRUMMOND

CEO of AviusULD

BY **Edward HARDY**

Charles Drummond is the CEO of AviusULD B.V., a ULD manufacturer and technology company, pioneering smart and sustainable unit load devices and IoT tracking solutions. A Mechatronics Engineer and Lean Six Sigma Black Belt, Drummond has over three decades of experience in industrial engineering, operations, and logistics. Australian, he has lived in Thailand for 14 years, leading multicultural teams across Asia, Europe, and the U.S. Known for his focus on innovation, operational excellence, and continuous improvement, Drummond is passionate about advancing digital transformation in the air cargo industry. Outside of work, he's a keen motorcyclist, rugby enthusiast, and proud father of two.

What was your dream job as a child?
I wanted to be a commercial pilot. The idea of flight and global travel fascinated me from an early age — it seems I still found my way into aviation, just from a different angle.

What's the biggest change you've seen in the industry?
The steady but unstoppable rise of digitisation. It's been fascinating to watch technology move from concept to adoption, transforming how we manage assets, track cargo, and think about efficiency and transparency.

What's the most unusual thing you've ever shipped?
Other than our products, AviusULD doesn't ship cargo ourselves, but I've always wondered how you would go about shipping a giraffe.

What's one buzzword you secretly dislike?
"Reach out." Somehow it feels a bit overused — I prefer a good old-fashioned "get in touch."

Window or aisle seat?
Window on long haul for the view — but aisle for short haul, purely for convenience.

What's the best business lesson you've learned the hard way?
Perfectionism can be the enemy of progress. I've learned that getting things done and iterating often beats waiting until something feels perfect.

If you could swap jobs with anyone for a day, who would it be?
Perhaps Elon Musk for a day — to see how he manages to balance such diverse, fast-moving technology businesses.

Which three items would you bring to a desert island?
An AviusULD SmartULD tag — so I'd be found quickly — a fishing rod, and a hammock.

Tea or coffee?
Coffee, without question. Early in my career, I worked for a subsidiary of Suntory in Australia that owned a coffee roasting and packing business — so I developed a lifelong appreciation for a great cup.

What's your guilty pleasure TV show or movie?
Any Tarantino film or a game of rugby.

What's the most exciting place you've visited for work?
It's hard to pick just one. The great thing about our industry is the opportunity to travel all over the world, experience new places, and connect with people from different cultures. Every trip offers something unique.

If you could introduce one new regulation in air cargo, what would it be?
More accountability for appropriate ULD handling. These are critical assets, and consistent global standards for care and responsibility would make a huge difference.

What's your go-to karaoke song?
Probably Sweet Caroline — it's impossible not to get the room singing along.

Describe your job in three words
Innovation. Kaizen. Mentorship.

What's your hidden talent?
I make a pretty mean cocktail — I'm a handy barman when the occasion calls for it.

If you could instantly master one skill, what would it be?
Polyglotism. I'd love to be able to switch languages effortlessly when working across cultures.

What's something on your bucket list?
To ride a motorcycle from Alaska to Patagonia — it's the ultimate adventure journey.

What's the best airport in the world, and why?
While I appreciate the big hubs like Dubai and Singapore, I value efficiency most. Helsinki Airport is my favourite when entering the EU — smooth arrivals, quick transfers, and a great Finnish gin in the lounge.

If air cargo had a mascot, what would it be?
A hummingbird — agile, precise, and tirelessly in motion. It may be small, but it achieves incredible feats through efficiency and endurance — just like the air cargo industry.

How did you get into airfreight/logistics?
I came to Thailand with Brambles, the world's largest asset pooling business, following their acquisition of Unitpool in 2011 — it was my introduction to the world of ULD management and aviation logistics.

What quote has most resonated with you?
Richard Branson's: "Clients do not come first. Employees come first. If you take care of your employees, they will take care of your clients." It captures the essence of sustainable success.

What's the most adventurous thing you've ever done?
I'm an avid adventure motorcyclist. My most recent long ride was a five-day trip around Lake Balkhash in Kazakhstan — an incredible mix of scenery, culture, and endurance.

If you could have dinner with any three people, living or dead, who would it be and why?
Anthony Bourdain for the conversation and food stories, Nelson Mandela for wisdom and perspective, and perhaps Steve Jobs — to talk about vision, design, and relentless curiosity.

What's something we wouldn't know about you from your CV?
That I'm happiest when I'm working with my hands — whether it's fixing an old motorbike, crafting something in the workshop, or mixing cocktails for friends.



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